

Solange Uwituze

(oo-wee-TOO-zeh)

Minister of State for Agriculture and Animal Resources
Republic of Rwanda

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Dec 2025**

Solange Uwituze is a U.S.-trained scientist whose policy agenda centers on raising agricultural productivity through more commercial and technology-driven farming.

- **A Sense of Obligation**
  After six years of study in America, Uwituze returned to Rwanda, explaining that "life is bigger than a paycheck." She noted "there's a sense of fulfillment in giving back to the community."

- **A Focus on Outcomes**
  Uwituze has little time for symbolic action. At the Africa Food Systems Forum in Kigali in September 2026, she called for moving "from commitments to investment, from investment to implementation, and from implementation to measurable results."

Uwituze's advocacy for women draws on her own path as the first female dean of the National University of Rwanda's agriculture faculty. She directed a USAID/HED-funded program that developed a gender-sensitive MSc in agribusiness designed to expand women's access to graduate education.

WHY THEY MATTER

Uwituze already treats soil health as a lever for productivity and has firsthand experience with microbial science, making her receptive to soil technologies but exacting about the evidence.

- **Soil Health's Promise**
  Uwituze sees soil fertility management as integral to how Rwanda organizes farm production and ties it to the PSTA 5 goal of raising priority crop productivity by more than 50 percent. She wants about 600,000 hectares, including Food Basket Sites, under conservation agriculture by 2029/30.

- **Private Capital's Pull**
  Uwituze seeks private investment and values technology-driven agri-food systems, but cautions that "technology will only transform agriculture if it reaches the ordinary farmer."

Uwituze brings technical fluency to the subject: she is a named inventor on U.S. patented technology involving microbial cells and animal-feed applications. She has published several peer-reviewed articles on livestock. Uwituze is a founding fellow of the Rwanda Academy of Sciences.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Uwituze speaks like a technocrat who wants to catalyze action from her counterparts and still be understood by ordinary people. She is comfortable admitting what still needs to be fixed and where there is room for improvement.

- **Ambitious, But Clear-eyed**
  Uwituze starts with policy, noting that "we really want to do our agriculture in a professional manner, in a commercial manner." She also wants agriculture seen as a business and a career, and her stated test of success includes "whether young people see agriculture as a viable business."

- **Casual, Yet Direct**
  Uwituze underscores the urgency of her task, imploring that "we need to get started like yesterday." She also raises the stakes by acknowledging that "a hungry population is an angry population... hungry people are literally overthrowing the governments."

A recommendation Uwituze wrote for a former colleague suggests what she prizes in others: she praised her as inquisitive, self-driven, dependable, and result-oriented. She has little patience for partnership as a slogan, asking instead for "named priorities, named people, and named dates."

ON THEIR MIND

- **2027A Agricultural Season's Launch**
  Prime Minister Dr. Justin Nsengiyumva officially launched the 2027A farming season. The main ceremony took place at the Nyarububa marshland (spanning Rukozo and Cyungo sectors), where the Prime Minister joined over 3,000 local participants to plant maize.

- **New Digital Loan Platform**
  National Bank of Rwanda Governor Soraya Hakuziyaremye in early October announced an initiative that aims to reduce the time smallholder farmers wait for agricultural loans from as long as seven weeks to less than 48 hours.

- **The Giseke Agricultural Irrigation Project**
  The Rwandan government broke ground on a US$47 million irrigation project that will bring controlled water supply to more than 2,600 hectares of farmland in Gisagara District. The Giseke Agricultural Irrigation Project, launched on 23 September, is financed by China Exim Bank and is being constructed by China Geo-Engineering Corporation.

- **Beninese President's Visit**
  President Romuald Wadagni in September toured the Rwanda Institute for Conservation Agriculture (RICA), where he explored modern approaches to livestock farming and sustainable agriculture. Wadagni was introduced to different aspects of cattle farming, including dairy production.

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NETWORK

Uwituze's international network is rooted in agricultural science and higher education rather than diplomacy; she has a deep familiarity with U.S. culture and Western institutions.

In addition to her education at Kansas State University, she spent 2014 to 2018 in Kampala with the Regional Universities Forum for Capacity Building in Agriculture (RUFORUM) and has managed projects funded by USAID, the European Union, Sida, DAAD, and the Carnegie Corporation of New York. She has said she was fascinated by Americans' work ethic and determination, as well as the comparatively less hierarchical nature of U.S. society, which "allows people to be judged by their performance."

At home, Uwituze is a trusted technocrat whose rise reflects President Kagame's confidence and her existing partnership with Minister for Agriculture and Animal Resources Telesphore Ndabamenye.

On her appointment in December 2025, she posted: "I sincerely thank you HE Paul Kagame for the Trust." She joined Kagame's delegation to Oman in September 2026, and was one of the Rwandan officials who signed the Rwanda-Oman agreements and MoUs, including cooperation in agriculture. Uwituze served as Ndabamenye's deputy at the Rwanda Agriculture and Animal Resources Development Board (RAB) and became acting director general when he moved to the ministry in July 2025. The ministry's chief technical adviser predicted that the pair would provide "co-creation leadership with partners, farmers, and donors."

CONTROVERSIES

Uwituze has not faced allegations of personal misconduct; the scrutiny she attracts concerns the performance of the institutions she has helped lead.

- **Auditor General Findings**
  In November 2025, while acting head of RAB, Uwituze appeared before a parliamentary commission after the Auditor General identified weaknesses in maize and rice handling, storage, drying facilities, and market linkages. Some publicly financed facilities were underused or poorly located; she acknowledged the problem and outlined corrective measures.

- **Missed Livestock Targets**
  In January 2025, Uwituze had to account for a missed milk production target, discussing drought and the interventions planned to increase output. She has also been the public face of efforts to address implementation gaps in livestock services, market access, insurance, extension, and post-harvest management.

Producers have also complained about the cost of entering the input market Uwituze promotes: one compost maker said eligibility to sell liquid organic fertilizer through agro-dealers could cost up to Rwf15 million.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of State for Agriculture and Animal Resources**, Republic of Rwanda (2025 to present)
- **Acting Director General**, Rwanda Agriculture and Animal Resources Development Board (2025)
- **Deputy Director General for Animal Resources Research and Technology Transfer**, Rwanda Agriculture and Animal Resources Development Board (2018 to 2025)
- **Program Manager**, Regional Universities Forum for Capacity Building in Agriculture (2014 to 2018)
- **Dean**, Faculty of Agriculture, National University of Rwanda (2012 to 2014)
- **Manager**, Preharvest Food Safety Laboratory, Kansas State University

BIO

Uwituze's life has been shaped by loss, faith, and return: a genocide survivor who earned a doctorate in Kansas and came home to teach. Born in the mid-1970s and raised in a French-speaking household, Uwituze earned a BSc in agriculture from the National University of Rwanda in 2002 and went to the United States on a Fulbright scholarship in 2005, completing an MSc (2008) and a PhD (2011) in animal sciences at Kansas State University.

- **Survival and Purpose**
  Uwituze was 19 during the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi, in which her father, two brothers, and members of her extended family were killed. She has encouraged fellow survivors to hold on to a sense of purpose, describing herself as a voice for the voiceless.

- **Faith and Science**
  In her doctoral dissertation, she thanked "the Almighty God for He has given me salvation, protection from harm and danger, provision for all my needs, peace, courage and perseverance to carry on when things got tough." She also acknowledged two of her professors "for modeling to me that science is not antagonistic with Christianity."

Uwituze's marital status and whether she has any children are not publicly known, but she is passionate about mentorship. In a 2023 social media post, she said: "Being a #teacher is one of most rewarding jobs I enjoyed. It allows to get a sense of fulfillment down the road when you see your former students succeeding in life 👌." She speaks Kinyarwanda, English, and French, with limited working proficiency in Swahili.